Present Perfect & Present Perfect Continuous

Both tenses link the past to NOW.
Something started or happened before now and still matters now.

PRESENT PERFECT · PP
the RESULT
What is done? How many? Up to now.

PRESENT PERFECT CONTINUOUS · PPC
the ACTIVITY
How long? Still going? What has been happening?

1 Present Perfect

have / has + V3



+	S + have / has + V3	*She has finished her homework.*
–	S + haven't / hasn't + V3	*We haven't seen that film.*
?	Have / Has + S + V3?	*Have you eaten? — Yes, I have. / No, I haven't.*

USES

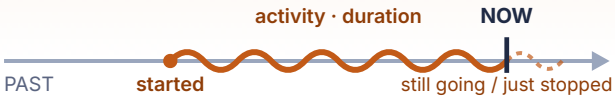
1 Experience (no time)	*I've been to Aswan twice.*
2 Result now	*I've lost my keys. (still lost)*
3 News / just happened	*The bus has just left.*
4 Unfinished time	*I've had three exams this week.*
5 State up to now	*I've known Ziad for ten years.*
6 How many so far	*He's scored two goals so far.*
7 Change over time	*Your English has improved a lot.*
8 Superlative + ever	*It's the best book I've ever read.*

Common V3 forms: be → been · go → gone · see → seen · eat → eaten · take → taken · write → written · do → done · buy → bought · make → made · have → had

V3, not V2: × ~~has went~~ ✓ has gone · **Short answer:** ✓ Yes, I have. × ~~Yes, I've.~~

2 Present Perfect Continuous

have / has + been + V-ing



+	S + have / has + been + V-ing	*It has been raining all day.*
–	S + haven't / hasn't + been + V-ing	*I haven't been sleeping well.*
?	Have / Has + S + been + V-ing?	*How long have you been waiting?*

USES

1 Still going now	*He's been waiting for an hour.*
2 Just stopped + evidence	*It's wet. It has been raining.*
3 Repeated · temporary	*I've been going to the gym lately.*
4 Complaining	*You've been playing that game all day!*
5 Short action repeated	*He's been coughing all night.*

Form check — has + been + V-ing: × ~~has being~~ × ~~has be working~~ × ~~has been work~~ ✓ has been working

-ing spelling: write → writing · run → running · lie → lying · study → studying

Answering "How long…?" → *For twenty minutes. / Since 3 o'clock.*

Signal words & where they go

have/has + already · just · ever · never · recently + V3

already PP
(+) mid or end · *I've already paid.*

yet PP
(–) and (?) · end · *Has he called yet?*

just PP
have + just + V3 · *They've just arrived.*

still PP
(–) before haven't · *He still hasn't replied.*

ever PP
(?) and superlatives · *Have you ever…?*

never PP
(+) form, (–) meaning · *I've never flown.*

before · so far · up to now PP
I've met him before. · in the last few years

for · since PP · PPC
I've lived / I've been living here since 2020.

recently · lately PP · PPC
I've been working hard lately. (recently also with PS)

How long…? PPC
with action verbs · *How long have you been studying?*

all day / all morning PPC
with action verbs · *It's been raining all day.*

just now · ago · How long ago? Past Simple
I saw him just now. How long ago did he leave?

Common errors: × ~~I haven't never…~~ ✓ I've never… · × ~~I have ever been to Paris.~~ ✓ I've been to Paris. · × ~~I have finished yet.~~ ✓ I haven't finished **yet**.

The core difference: result vs activity

How many? → PP · How long? → PPC

Difference	Present Perfect — result / completed	Present Perfect Continuous — activity / duration
Result / activity	*I've cleaned my room.* → now it's tidy	*I've been cleaning my room.* → that's why I'm tired
Finished / not yet	*Karim has read the book.* (page 300 of 300)	*Karim has been reading the book.* (page 120 of 300)
Number / duration	*He has written three emails.*	*He has been writing emails all morning.*
All / part	*Someone has eaten my sandwich!* (plate empty)	*Someone has been eating my sandwich!* (half missing)

Both are fine with **live, work, study, teach** + for/since: *I've worked / I've been working here for five years.* (PPC can sound more temporary.)

since · for · been · gone

since	+ a **point**: 2020 · Monday · 8 o'clock · last week · I was a child
for	+ a **period**: six years · two hours · a week · ages · the last two years

× ~~since two years~~ × ~~for 2019~~ × ~~since a week~~

since + clause → Past Simple: *I've known him since we **were** kids.*

been to	went and came back · *Omar has been to Alexandria.*
gone to	is still there · *Dad has gone to work.*

Stative verbs — no -ing

even with for / since

Mind	know, believe, think (= opinion), understand, mean
Feeling	like, love, hate, prefer, want, need
Owning	own, belong, have (= possess)
Senses	see, hear, smell, taste
Other	be, seem, cost, contain, weigh, depend

Action meaning → -ing is OK

have	(eat) *We've been having lunch.*	**think**	(consider) *I've been thinking about it.*
see	(visit) *He's been seeing a doctor.*	**feel**	(body) *I've been feeling tired lately.*

× ~~I've been knowing him for years.~~ ✓ I've known him for years. In exams, a stative verb takes no -ing.

PP or Past Simple?

a finished time means Past Simple

yesterday · …ago · last… · in 2019 · When…? → PS: × ~~I have seen him yesterday.~~ ✓ I saw him yesterday.

"this morning" — still morning? (10 a.m.) *I've sent five emails this morning.* · (4 p.m.) *I sent…*

for + a finished period → PS: *He worked in Kuwait for five years.* (he's back) · *He has worked there…* (still there)

Life over / chance gone → PS: *Einstein won the Nobel Prize.* × ~~has won~~

★ Exam tricks

the shortcuts that decide multiple-choice answers

1 How many / how much done? → PP, not PPC

✓ I've drunk four cups today. × ~~I've been drinking four cups.~~

A length of time is fine: *I've been waiting for two hours.*

2 How long? + action verb → PPC

How long have you been waiting? · stative verb → PP: *How long have you known him?*

3 It's the first time… → PP

× ~~It's the first time I see snow.~~ ✓ …I've seen snow.

Past: *It was the first time I had seen snow.*

4 Up to now + for/since → not Present Simple / Continuous

× ~~I'm waiting for an hour.~~ ✓ I've been waiting for an hour.

5 been + V-ing = active · been + V3 = passive

He has been cleaning the room. (he does it) · *The room has been cleaned.* (passive)

6 he's = he has or he is?

has + V3 / been (active): *He's gone. He's been working.*

is + V-ing / adjective / passive: *He's going out. He's tired. He's called Ali.*

Key transformations

…ago → for · in / on / at → since

I started learning French two years ago.	→ **I've been learning French for two years.**
The last time I saw Karim was in June.	→ **I haven't seen Karim since June.**
It's three years since I saw him.	→ **I haven't seen him for three years.**
This is my first visit to Luxor.	→ **I've never visited Luxor before.**
I bought this phone two years ago. (still mine)	→ **I've had this phone for two years.**
I've never seen such a big fish.	→ **It's the biggest fish I've ever seen.**

Decision map

ask in this order

1. Finished time word? — **PAST SIMPLE**
2. Stative verb? — **PP**
3. How many / how much done? — **PP**
4. Duration · still going · evidence? — **PPC**
5. ever · just · already · yet? — **PP (usually)**

Context decides — these are strong exam patterns, not unbreakable laws.